



BEFORE

Thanks to reforms overseen by Senator John C. Calhoun—President James Monroe’s secretary of war from 1817 to 1825 (see [The Jacksonian age](#))—the U.S. Army was the most sophisticated bureaucratic organization in mid-19th-century America.

READY FOR SMALL-SCALE WAR

Despite a primitive transportation infrastructure and a penny-pinching Congress, the **prewar army supplied and equipped troops** across a continent-wide frontier. Arms were stockpiled in **federal and state arsenals**, such as [Harpers Ferry](#). Shortages of weapons occurred on both sides at the start of the Civil War because stocks were never intended to supply such huge numbers of soldiers.

When the war began, the North had clear economic and industrial advantages over the South. Yet in spite—or perhaps because—of this, the Union had at first an astonishing capacity for undermining its position through self-inflicted mistakes. Alongside this, the North also faced the logistical difficulties of supplying armies of invasion in hostile territory.

The North’s faltering start

One of the North’s first challenges to efficient mobilization was Lincoln’s choice of secretary of war—Simon Cameron, a veteran of the seedy side of prewar politics. Appointed for political reasons, Cameron presided over a War Department rife with corruption and profiteering. In the words of a Congressional investigating committee, Cameron’s poor judgment led to “a system of public policy [that] must lead inevitably to personal favoritism at the public expense, the corruption of public morals, and a ruinous profligacy in the expenditure of public treasure.” Things improved after January 1862, when Lincoln replaced Cameron with former Attorney General Edwin Stanton, who brought much needed energy, efficiency, and honesty to the War Department.

Montgomery Meigs, the other major figure in managing the North’s resources, was a U.S. Army officer who became head of the Quartermaster Bureau in May 1861, after his predecessor, Joseph E. Johnston, left to join the Confederacy. Meigs’s bureau supplied the armies with material, other than weapons and food, which included the infrastructure necessary to transport these supplies. During the